Northwind Labs - Engineering Employee Handbook

Sample - fictional company. All names, policies, and figures are invented for demonstration purposes.

Effective October 1, 2026. Maintained by Human Resources (Sophia Martinez, Head of HR).

1. Welcome and Purpose

Welcome to the Engineering department at Northwind Labs. Engineering builds and maintains Northwind Labs' software and hardware products, from the cloud analytics platform to the edge telemetry toolkit.

This handbook covers policies specific to Engineering employees. The department is led by Dr. Aris Thorne (Head of Engineering). Where this handbook and a company-wide policy differ, this handbook applies to Engineering employees.

2. Work Hours and Offices

Engineering uses flexible core hours: every engineer is expected to be available between 10:00 AM and 3:00 PM local office time, Monday through Friday. Outside core hours, engineers may set their own schedule as long as they work a 40-hour week.

Northwind Labs has three offices. Office hours and office contacts are:

Office	Hours	Office contact	Email
New York	Mon-Fri 9:00 AM - 5:00 PM EST	Marcus Cole	ny-office@northwind.example
London	Mon-Fri 8:30 AM - 4:30 PM GMT	Fiona Gallagher	london-office@northwind.example
Austin	Mon-Fri 8:00 AM - 5:00 PM CST	Travis Reed	austin-office@northwind.example

3. Remote and Hybrid Work

Engineers may work remotely up to 3 days per week. Tuesdays and Thursdays are in-office anchor days for the whole department. Fully remote arrangements require written approval from the Head of Engineering.

4. Paid Time Off

Engineering employees accrue 20 days of paid time off (PTO) per year. PTO requests of 5 or more consecutive days must be submitted at least 3 weeks in advance. No PTO may be scheduled during a quarterly code freeze without manager approval. Up to 5 unused PTO days may be carried over into the next calendar year.

Sick leave is separate from PTO: every employee receives 8 paid sick days per year. A doctor's note is required only for absences longer than 3 consecutive work days.

Parental leave is 16 weeks fully paid for the primary caregiver and 8 weeks fully paid for the secondary caregiver.

5. Company Holidays and Closures

The following company holidays and closures apply to all departments for the 2026-2027 season:

Date	Holiday	Status
Thursday, November 26, 2026	Thanksgiving Day	All offices closed
Friday, November 27, 2026	Day after Thanksgiving	All offices closed
Thursday, December 24, 2026	Christmas Eve	Modified hours - offices close at 1:00 PM
Friday, December 25, 2026	Christmas Day	All offices closed
Friday, January 1, 2027	New Year's Day	All offices closed

Employees required to work on a company holiday receive a substitute day off, to be taken within 90 days.

6. On-Call Rotation and Code Freeze

Engineers on the production on-call rotation serve one week at a time, Monday 9:00 AM to the following Monday 9:00 AM. On-call engineers receive a stipend of $400 per on-call week.

A page must be acknowledged within 15 minutes. If the primary on-call engineer does not acknowledge, the page escalates to the secondary on-call engineer, then to the engineering manager on duty.

Each on-call week earns 1 extra day of PTO, to be used within 60 days.

Quarterly code freezes lock the main repositories for platform maintenance. During a freeze only approved hotfixes may be merged. The winter release freeze begins Friday, December 18, 2026; after 12:00 PM that day only on-call staff are expected to be working.

The monthly All-Hands Tech Talk is held on Fridays and is open to the whole department.

7. Equipment and Allowances

Each engineer receives a laptop refresh every 3 years and a one-time home-office stipend of $750 for a monitor, chair, or desk. Equipment requests go through the IT Help Desk.

8. Training and Development

Every engineer has an annual learning budget of $2,000 for courses, books, and conferences. Conference travel counts against this budget and needs manager approval at least 30 days before the event.

9. Benefits Enrollment

Open enrollment for health benefits runs from November 2 to November 20, 2026. New hires must enroll within 30 days of their start date.

Northwind Labs matches 401(k) contributions dollar-for-dollar up to 5% of salary. Employees are eligible for the match after 90 days of employment.

10. Conduct and Reporting Concerns

Concerns about harassment, discrimination, or safety can be reported to your manager, to Human Resources, or anonymously through the Northwind Labs ethics hotline. Retaliation against anyone who reports a concern in good faith is prohibited.

Questions about corporate governance, regulatory compliance, or contracts go to the Legal department, led by Rachel Vance (Head of Legal).

11. Who to Contact

Engineering policy questions: Dr. Aris Thorne (Head of Engineering).

Pay, benefits, and leave: Human Resources - Sophia Martinez (Head of HR).

Laptops, accounts, and access: the IT Help Desk.

Badges, physical security, and workplace safety incidents: Security - Nathan Brooks (Director of Security).